Phulbari lies in the Sonitpur district of Assam, North of the Brahmaputra River. There used to be a military garrison here as part of 5 Mountain Division. After the Sumdorung Chu incident in 1987, units of 5 Mountain Division had been moved forward to the Tawang sector of Arunachal Pradesh as part of Op Chequerboard that followed and remained deployed there. As a result, the garrison had remained unoccupied, except for a Platoon left behind for security duties. Over these two decades in the damp and humid weather, all the buildings had disintegrated and trees were growing inside the barracks, with their tops jutting out through the roofs. The jungle had reclaimed its space. At first glance, it looked exactly like Angkor Vat, only worse. 10 MADRAS along with the HQ of 106 Inf Bde was to be located here. About 10 km to the West was the garrison of Thakurbari—HQ 77 Mountain Brigade along with its Battalions, who were deployed in CI/CT operations in upper Assam. Space had been made in this garrison for 7 BIHAR. Since this garrison was a functional one, it was pretty much comfortable, with all the basic amenities. Approximately midway was Amrabari, where the third Battalion was to be located, along with some of the Brigade HQ elements, which could not be accommodated within Phulbari. This location had been fully reclaimed by the jungle and from the track connecting these locations, even a single barrack was not to be seen. Moreover, over the years, the villagers had made off with whatever they could lay their hands on: doors, windows, electrical fittings, roofing sheets, even the switchboards and fuses. What was left was just an empty shell reeking of decay and despondency.

But that's the hand we had been dealt with and we had to make the most of it. We, the team comprising Col Makol, the Dy Cdr; Lt Col Sameer Sharma, Bde GSO 1 (Ops); Lt

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